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Apple Trees and Plastic Ducks: Gardens as Post-pastoral Landscapes in Contemporary British Fiction

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ABSTRACT
Gardens have long occupied a prominent place in the British cultural imagination. Recently, the compounding crises of climate change and the COVID-19 pandemic brought both the degradation of the environment and the problems with an industrial food chain into sharper focus, driving a new surge of interest in gardening. Yet, although in the popular imagination gardens are seen as idyllic sanctuaries, their depiction in contemporary fiction is often not so straightforward. In this paper, I explore how four British female authors depict gardens, altering traditional garden symbolism to reflect the post-pastoral ethos of much contemporary writing. Using examples from works by Claire-Louise Bennett, Jessie Greengrass, Daisy Hildyard, and Sarah Moss, I show how gardens are reimagined as less idyllic, yet more powerful spaces. This approach allows the four authors to highlight the artificiality of the Manichean distinctions between nature and civilisation, wilderness and society, and the human and non-human.

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Post-pastoral Gardens: Gardening in Uncertain Times

Gardens and gardening have occupied a prominent place in the British cultural imagination for many centuries. From the introduction of formal horticulture and vegetable production to the British Isles in the Roman era, through the enclosed gardens of the great medieval monasteries and the "natural" landscape gardens of the eighteenth century,[1] up to the urban allotments of the twentieth and twenty-first centuries, the British garden has been an ever-changing, yet constantly present aspect of British life. By 2004, garden ownership in Britain had "expanded to the point where there are now over twenty million private gardens – by far the highest number per capita of any nation in Europe".[2] Gardening is without doubt "the nation's most popular and widespread leisure activity",[3] and its popularity has only increased further in recent years; according to a 2020 study by the Office for National Statistics, 88% of British households have "access to a private or shared garden".[4]

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[1]Amherst, *A History of Gardening in England*.
[2]Alfrey, Daniels, and Postle, *Art of the Garden*, 9.
[3]Ibid.
[4]Office for National Statistics, "One in Eight British Households Has No Garden."

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The surge of interest in gardening is reflected in the growing demand for allotments. While Charles Elliott noted that the total area of allotments in Britain had fallen from a high of 533,000 acres in the 1970s to just 297,000 by 1996, with a corresponding reduction in waiting times for such sites,[5] the beginning of the twenty-first century saw a reversal of this trend. In 2023 Damien Gayle reported in *The Guardian* that allotment waitlists have almost doubled over the last decade to an average period of 3 years,[6] a trend which is corroborated by similar findings by the Royal Horticultural Society from 2025.[7]

There are many reasons behind the continuing interest in gardening. As early as 1998, the Environment, Transport and Regional Affairs Select Committee of the House of Commons noted that concerns about environmental and food system issues would likely increase interest in gardening and allotment demand,[8] and these predictions have proven to be correct. The lack of any substantial effort to respond to the impending environmental catastrophe at the national or supranational level has driven many to seek out their own individual means of adapting to the crisis, and the issue of how we produce food and whether the methods we currently employ are sustainable on a rapidly heating planet represent a significant part of this conversation.

These debates gained a sense of urgency during and after the COVID-19 pandemic, a global crisis which raised concerns about the reliability of industrial food supply chains and the rights of farm workers and others employed in industrial-scale food production. The profound sense of loss of control caused by the compounding stresses of mobility restrictions, empty supermarket shelves, and the fear of infection led many to embrace gardening, or more specifically crisis or panic gardening, as a coping mechanism.[9] This essentially individual approach to the crisis was particularly marked in a country like the UK, where many households had access to private gardens which were accessible even during periods of lockdown or quarantine. Guy Barter, the Royal Horticultural Society's chief horticulturist, estimated that approximately three million people took up gardening in 2020, with a particular focus on growing food, especially staples like onions, potatoes, or salad greens.[10] However, the idea of panic gardening is by no means a modern phenomenon, and the activity has clear echoes to the mass adoption of victory gardening during the two world wars.[11] Growing one's own food empowers and grounds us in times of stress, fear, and uncertainty. In such times, gardening and gardens become, both literally and metaphorically, places of calm, control, and sanctuary.

It is precisely these metaphorical associations of gardens that are the subject of this paper. I first became interested in the literary depictions of gardens relatively recently when, while reading a selection of British pandemic novels as part of another research project, I noticed that the authors frequently draw parallels between the more recent crisis of the pandemic and other, more familiar crises, such as the climate crisis or the midlife crisis. Garden imagery often features prominently in the narratives of pandemic

[5]Elliott, *The Potting-Shed Papers,* 137.
[6]Gayle, "Waiting List for Allotments in England Almost Doubles in 12 Years."
[7]The Royal Horticultural Society, "Allotment Basics."
[8]Environment, Transport and Regional Affairs Select Committee, *Environment, Transport and Regional Affairs – Fifth Report.*
[9]See Cunningham, "'Panic Gardening' is Growing Interest in Backyard Food Crops"; Horvath, "Crisis Gardening"; or Larner, "'Panic Gardening' during a Pandemic."
[10]Barter, "2021 Gardening Predictions."
[11]Cunningham, "'Panic Gardening' is Growing Interest in Backyard Food Crops."

novels, but these depictions do not always conform to the standard framing of gardens in the crisis gardening discourse in the media and amongst the general population, in which gardens are typically posited as sanctuaries or places of escape. In this paper, I explore the depiction of gardens in contemporary British fiction through a discussion of four works: *Pond* (2015) by Claire Louise Bennett, *The High House* (2021) by Jesse Greengrass, *The Fell* (2021) by Sarah Moss, and *Emergency* (2022) by Daisy Hildyard. I argue that these four authors adopt what Terry Gifford calls a post-pastoral narrative mode[12] in their depictions of gardens; in adapting the pastoral tradition for the climate crisis era, the novels thus represent a rejection of the anthropocentric framework in favour of a post-humanist approach. All four authors make use of the techniques of fragmentation and gleaning, thereby allowing them to decentre their human characters and create more space for non-human ones while also locating a middle ground between idealistic and dystopian depictions of the natural world.

The pastoral mode has been an influential and enduring approach to writing about nature throughout the Western literary canon. The main trope of pastoralism is the juxtaposition between urban complexity and a romanticised rural simplicity. Within such a framework, the farms, meadows, and gardens of the countryside function as the ideal "middle landscape" between urban civilisation and the untamed wilderness devoid of humans.[13] Greg Garrard notes that the pastoral mode rests on the premise of "nature as a stable, enduring counterpoint to the disruptive energy and change of human societies".[14] As such, the pastoral landscape serves as a retreat in which the jaded minds of city-dwellers can recharge, contemplate, and rediscover themselves within a balmy and pristine natural environment.

The belief in the healing and stabilising power of natural environments is enduring. In *Everybody Needs Beauty: In Search of the Nature Cure* Samantha Walton notes that throughout history, a certain therapeutic potential has been ascribed to pastoral landscapes. Places such as gardens, farms, and forests "have been invested with a distinctive power to heal".[15] However, in the twenty-first century, the problems associated with what is variously referred to as nature, the environment, ecosystems, or the biosphere have become a major presence in our collective consciousness. Naturally, literature reflects these preoccupations. This is evident in the resurgence of interest in nature writing at the beginning of the century,[16] the emergence of the new genre of climate fiction,[17] or in the general turn of contemporary fiction towards realism and materialism, especially in the case of fiction written by women.[18] However, the concept of nature's essential benignity or stability that has underpinned the pastoral mode for centuries has now lost its validity; nature in the contemporary world appears to be anything but "easeful, plentiful, pretty, instructive or enduring".[19] In tandem with a reinvigorated interest in

[12]See Gifford, *Pastoral*. The concept of post-pastoral will be discussed in more detail later in this article.
[13]Marx, *The Machine in the Garden,* 22.
[14]Garrard, *Ecocriticism,* 56.
[15]Walton, *Everybody Needs Beauty,* 17.
[16]See Kerridge, "Nature Writing."
[17]See Thieme, *Anthropocene Realism*.
[18]See Anjaria, "Twenty-first-century Realism"; Dalley, "The Return of Realism in the World Novel"; Tew and Mengham, *British Fiction Today*; Turner, "Realism, Women Writers and the Contemporary British Novel"; Walezak, *Rethinking Contemporary British Women's Writing*; and elsewhere.
[19]Garrard, *Ecocriticism,* 48.

writing about nature, we are witnessing a simultaneous questioning of not only the pastoral mode, but of the idea of "nature" itself.

As early as 1964 Leo Marx had noted that industrialisation had fundamentally altered the relationship between humans and the planet on which they live. Marx observed that the Industrial Revolution had allowed technological power, symbolised by the train, to escape the boundaries of the city, thereby "transforming the sensory texture of rural life – the way it looks and sounds – and threatening, in fact, to impose a new and more complete dominion over it".[20] In the United States, at least, this had come to pass: the machine had entered the garden, and it has never gone away. Ten years later, John Barrell and John Bull, the editors of *The Penguin Book of English Pastoral Verse* announced the death of the pastoral in English poetry on account that

> [t]he separation of life in the town and in the country that the Pastoral demands is now almost devoid of any meaning. It is difficult to pretend that the English countryside is now anything more than an extension of the town [and] that the Pastoral has not become in fact just another trip, another Sunday afternoon drive.[21]

Now, more than half a century later, it is impossible to deny the fact that human activity, more specifically industrialisation and the burning of fossil fuels, is having significant effects on every being and object on our planet. The era of the Anthropocene is upon us, and we have become acutely aware that there is no longer any unspoiled countryside to which we can escape from our urban civilisation. The entire world is affected by human technology, from the intensive agricultural operations that now dominate rural areas to the microplastics floating in even the most remote parts of the oceans. The timeless and idyllic settings of the bucolic poems of yesteryear seem almost beyond our imagination.

Along with the realisation that we are transforming the Earth in such a way that it might soon be uninhabitable for our own species, we have gradually realised that humans are not in fact a unique and distinct entity which exists in separation from the rest of our planet; we are instead fatally "intermeshed" with the reminder of matter and absolutely dependent upon it for our survival. This notion of entanglement, of humanity forming part of the so-called "environment" rather than being simply surrounded by it, has been proposed by many scholars in the humanities, the philosophy of science, and environmental studies. Stacy Alaimo introduced the notion of being intermeshed, or trans-corporeality, in her book *Bodily Natures: Science, Environment, and the Material Self*, while similar conceptions of the relationship between human and nonhuman/more-than-human entities have been suggested by Donna Haraway, who calls this phenomenon natureculture, that is "the implosion of nature and culture".[22]

In her essay "Unruly Edges: Mushrooms as Companion Species" Anna Tsing builds on Donna Haraway's conception of multispecies relationships. Tsing notes that while species interdependence among non-human beings is accepted as "a well-known fact", in Western culture humans have for long considered themselves exempt from such dependencies.[23] Instead, Western thought has been shaped by the idea of human

[20]Marx, *The Machine in the Garden,* 32.
[21]Barrell and Bull, *The Penguin Book of English Pastoral Verse*, 432.
[22]Haraway, *The Companion Species Manifesto,* 16.
[23]Tsing, "Unruly Edges," 144.

exceptionalism which dictates that humans can and should take control over the rest of the natural world. However, current research in biology, ecology, or anthropology refutes the notion of human exceptionalism. Drawing on this research, Tsing claims human nature itself has evolved as an interspecies relationship, as a mutual shaping between the human and non-human, not as a one-way process of domestication and domination.

The idea of interspecies entanglement and of the fluidity of boundaries between agents in the environment was also put forward by Karen Barad. Barad understands individual beings as forged through mutual interactions rather than as already-formed entities entering interactions, a type of relationship she refers to as intra-action.[24] According to Barad, bodies are not separate entities that occupy a specific space and time in the world. Rather, they are "performances of the world's dynamic reconfiguring".[25] These performances are always embodied, and as such are not "specifically situated *in* the world" but instead are "*of* the world in its dynamic specificity".[26]

With the meaning of such fundamental concepts as nature, environment, and the pastoral now under question, authors are forced to ask themselves whether it is even possible to write about nature and if so, how to go about it. Is the pastoral mode still useful in the twenty-first century? Is there any point in writing about "nature" if everything around us can be considered as nature? How useful is the concept of "environment" if we are unable to separate ourselves from it? Underlying these questions is a deeper problem, the problem of coping with our collective solastalgia: a nostalgia for our planet as we know it as it disappears before our eyes.[27] Thus, above all else, fiction writers of the twenty-first century are forced to grapple with the question posed by Timothy Morton in *The Ecological Thought*: "How do we move forward from the melancholy of a poisoned planet?"[28]

Ever since it first developed in ancient Greece, the genre of the pastoral and its later evolution into a mode or tradition has been marked by a self-conscious awareness of the impossibility of the rural Eden for which it yearned. Terry Gifford notes that in European literature a thread of anti-pastoralism "was embedded within the most complex pastorals from the *Idylls* onwards".[29] Leo Marx came to a similar conclusion when studying the pastoral in the American context, making a "distinction between two kinds of pastoralism – one that is popular and sentimental, the other imaginative and complex".[30] While the former is characterised by a naïve, "inchoate longing for a more 'natural' environment",[31] the latter does not

> permit us to come away with anything like the simple, affirmative attitude we adopt toward pleasing rural scenery. In one way or another, if only by virtue of the unmistakable sophistication with which they are composed, these works manage to qualify, or call into question, or bring irony to bear against the illusion of peace and harmony in a green pasture.[32]

[24]Barad, *Meeting the Universe Halfway,* 34.
[25]Barad, "Invertebrate Visions," 229.
[26]Ibid., emphasis added.
[27]Albrecht, "Solastalgia."
[28]Morton, *The Ecological Thought,* 2.
[29]Gifford, "Pastoral, Anti-Pastoral, and Post-Pastoral," 22.
[30]Marx, *The Machine in the Garden,* 5.
[31]Ibid.
[32]Ibid., 25.

Gifford uses the term "post-pastoral" to refer to works, both contemporary and earlier, that attempt to reach beyond "the limitations of pastoral while being recognizably in the pastoral tradition".[33] The post-pastoral mode critically engages with and reflects upon the pastoral, "seeking not a stable, complacent form of harmony in the human relationship with nature – our species' relationship with its home planet in its macro and its micro ecologies – but seeking a dynamic, self-adjusting accommodation to 'discordant harmonies'".[34] Post-pastoral texts engage with the problem of the human attitude to the natural landscape, asking whether awe can foster humility; they focus on the "implications of recognizing that we are part of that creative-destructive process" – of the "ebbs and flows of growth and decay", contending with the questions of human consciousness and how it mediates our relationship with the rest of matter and pondering the interconnections between culture and nature. They question the cultural implications of the belief that humans (and by extension, human culture and technology) are part of nature and attempt to understand what makes us so prone to exploiting the Earth.[35] Finally, post-pastoral texts are those "that successfully suggest a collapse of the human/nature divide while being aware of the problematics involved".[36] Given this broader context, the post-pastoral seems to be a particularly useful mode for writing about nature in the Anthropocene.

Indeed, the four books under study in this paper all employ the post-pastoral mode; the gardens and landscapes depicted within them serve as vehicles for a nuanced exploration of the (natural) world which acknowledges the tentativeness of harmony and the interconnectedness of all the actors in nature. The capacity of gardens to serve such a purpose might be surprising, especially considering the more traditional connotations which they bear. According to the Merriam-Webster dictionary, the English word *garden* has roots in the Old German word *gart*, which means enclosure, and gardens have often been designed as spaces "set apart from the pressures of ordinary life for pleasure and contemplation".[37] In many mythologies gardens are synonymous with paradise, "the imagined locus of our beginning and end [...] whose inhabitants are divinely protected", existing in "a preconscious state of innocence and harmony".[38] Indeed, even in contemporary understandings, the garden frequently conjures images of privacy, pleasure, peace, and control, "suggesting an aspirational aesthetic that is romantic and resolutely non-urban".[39]

Yet, despite these deeply held associations, in reality

> [w]e can never wholly domesticate a garden anymore than we can wholly domesticate the soul. Even our most compulsive efforts to control or manipulate the garden are subject to the autonomy, randomness and surprises of nature. Priapus, Saint Augustine reminds us, embodies the endlessly proliferating spirit of the garden. And how easily the untended garden returns to wilderness, its matted overgrowth and tangled vines encroaching on all our emblems of civilization.[40]

[33]Gifford, "Pastoral, Anti-Pastoral, and Post-Pastoral," 26.
[34]Ibid., 28.
[35]Ibid, 27.
[36]Ibid., 26.
[37]Ronnberg, *The Book of Symbols,* 146
[38]Ibid.
[39]Bhatti, Church, and Claremont, "Peaceful, Pleasant and Private," 46.
[40]Ronnberg, *The Book of Symbols*, 148.

The garden of paradise always remains an ideal, an unattainable utopia, a product of the sentimental pastoral. In reality, gardens are more like Michel Foucault's "heterotopias", "contradictory sites ... capable of juxtaposing in a single real place several spaces, several sites that are in themselves incompatible".[41] Although a garden is often enclosed within the boundaries of a fence, it contains a teeming mass of converging worlds. The soil is turned into plants, plants into animals, and animals back into soil; the human mingles with the non-human; culture creates nature and nature sustains culture. The complexity, contingency, permeability, and transience of gardens make them post-pastoral landscapes par excellence.

Out-of-control Gardens as Permeable Sanctuaries

The four works examined in this paper all share a melancholy mood suffused with solastalgia, however, this does not prevent their characters from acting in the world. The world as depicted in the four books is huge, complex, and often incomprehensible, yet its inhabitants refuse to submit in their struggle for survival. This struggle is most explicitly depicted in Jessie Greengrass's *The High House*, a climate fiction novel set in a near future in which a huge flood has rendered most of Britain uninhabitable. Caro and her half-brother Pauly forge an existence in a safe house surrounded by a garden and orchard which had been created for them by Caro's mother in anticipation of the coming disaster. They share this sanctuary with two villagers, Sally and her grandfather whom the others call Grandy. As they work together to grow vegetables and preserve fruits, their acute feelings of fear, despair, and guilt are counterbalanced by the happiness and contentment which they find in the beauty and bounty of the garden and in the companionship which they offer each other.

The other three works under study also evoke mixed feelings of fear, guilt, melancholy, awe, and joy. Daisy Hildyard's *Emergency* was subtitled *A Pastoral Novel* in its American edition, a decision which ostentatiously situates the work within the long-standing tradition. Despite its rural setting, however, the unnamed narrator has not withdrawn from urban life; she was born and raised in a small village somewhere in the north of England and does not venture beyond its bounds. Yet the outside world intrudes in many forms, such as the exotic spider brought home by accident in a bag of bananas or the village's first computer installed in the local school. The village, in turn, spills out into the world, mostly in the form of the cement produced by the local quarry and the pork raised and slaughtered in the nearby pigsties. There is no escape and no return in Hildyard's pastoral; instead, the local and the global, the rural and the urban, and nature and technology are all deeply enmeshed and constantly intra-acting. The narrator lives her life surrounded by a group of neighbours and other feral kids from the village, running around the maze of unfenced gardens that never seem to end, flowing out instead into the fields, forests, and quarries that circle the village.

In these gardens, the narrator and her friends are confronted by a world in which beauty and cruelty are both essential elements of life, and where they discover the paradoxical truth that love and care can often unwittingly lead to violence. One such episode takes place after the rabbit the narrator's parents are raising in their garden gives birth to

[41]Foucault, "Of Other Spaces," 25.

"a nest full of babies".[42] Although her mother warns her against it, the young girl cannot resist the impulse to take one of the baby rabbits out of the run and "take care" of it. Although her intentions are pure, the consequences are grim; when she returns the baby to the rabbit run, the mother rabbit detects the narrator's strange smell and devours her own litter.

> The following day I went to see the rabbits and the mother was alone in her run. She was truly a big rabbit. I watched her for a while. She seemed calm, nibbling dandelion leaves, and I felt a sense of affinity with her because we had done it together, destroyed the babies with our colossal care. Even today, she seems to me very human in the way her principles forced her to self-destruct, and in the scale of her appetite, which far exceeded what she needed to survive – those dandelion leaves.[43]

This episode represents a crucial encounter in which the narrator is made aware of the inescapability of the fact that life, sustenance, care, violence, and death are all indelible parts of existence. In *The Eye of the Crocodile*, Val Plumwood recounts her own close encounter with death, when she was almost eaten by a crocodile while canoeing in Kakadu National Park. This event had a profound influence on Plumwood: it represented a "moment of truth" in which "abstract knowledge" about the cycle of matter and inevitability of death suddenly became concrete.[44] After almost becoming the crocodile's food, Plumwood was forced to accept that the "apartness" of humans from other animals and the rest of life on Earth is purely an illusion.[45] Moreover, the scene perfectly illustrates the notion put forth by Donna Haraway that "[t]ouch and regard have consequences".[46] By touching the baby rabbits, the narrator assumes responsibility for their fate. By looking into the mother rabbit's face, by immersing herself in the "intersecting gaze",[47] she learns to understand the rabbit's perspective. Just like Plumwood, who gained a crucial understanding of her own "vulnerability as an edible, animal being" by gazing into the eyes of the crocodile who attacked her,[48] the narrator acquires a "sense of affinity" with the natural world through gazing at the mother rabbit.

The narrator of *Emergency* is still a child when the rabbit episode takes place, yet this striking and intimate encounter with death, albeit not her own, becomes a powerful lesson in physicality and mortality and encapsulates what Plumwood jokingly describes as the "essential foodiness" shared by all animals, including the narrator.[49] It also serves to highlight the entanglement of life forms that coexist in any ecosystem, including the garden. Through this encounter, the garden is revealed as a source of sustenance for both its human and non-human inhabitants alike, yet it is also a nexus for all kinds of violence: accidental, casual, or intentional. The novel forces us to realise that violence, love, and appetite are all much more similar than we would like to admit.

Sarah Moss's *The Fell* adopts a similar approach to the idea of the garden. Set during the COVID-19 pandemic, the characters of the novel are confined to their homes and private yards as part of the national effort to prevent the spread of the virus, but their

[42]Hildyard, *Emergency*, 10.
[43]Ibid., 14.
[44]Plumwood, *The Eye of the Crocodile*, 10.
[45]Ibid., 14.
[46]Haraway, *When Species Meet*, 36.
[47]Ibid., 21.
[48]Plumwood, *The Eye of the Crocodile*, 10.
[49]Ibid., 91.

attitudes towards the spaces which offer them a sense of escape during quarantine are highly ambivalent. The characters are aware of the connotations of the garden as a site of sanctuary, a safe space set apart from the rest of the world; on this basis, they rationally acknowledge their access to gardens as a benefit, appreciating that they can leave their houses to tend to their flowers and vegetables and rely on the produce while they are unable to shop at the supermarket. Echoing the rhetoric of the traditional pastoral mode, they comment on the beauty and tranquillity of their gardens. In the early days of her quarantine, the protagonist, Kate, wanders through her garden, observing:

> There will be daffodils along the path here in spring, and tulips over there, the dark purple ones sold as black. She's never planted so many bulbs before. [...] The kale's holding up, they should have some more of that tonight [...] There's birdsong now, some small piping voice in the hedge; wind, not much, in the bare apple tree. From here she can see across the fields to the hill, where the bracken is dying and the heather dull brown, cloud brushing the summit.[50]

Her neighbour Alice fondly reminisces about how she loved visiting the garden centre before it closed because of the lockdown, relishing "that particular sunny smell of compost and green growing, the wobble of a wheelbarrow when you pick up a rose bush and some tomato seedlings".[51] Yet while these descriptions, with their sensory imagery and focus on the pleasantness and idyllic character of the garden, are clear allusions to the pastoral tradition, Moss infuses each of them with a darker mood. Alice muses on the possibility that what she really enjoyed about the garden centre was not the beauty of the plants but rather the act of shopping, while Kate despairs over the fact that even though she grows her own vegetables, the resulting meals almost always end up as "some kind of vegetable and tinned tomato slop on rice".[52] And despite the solace which their gardens grant them, both Alice and Kate long to escape their bounds, guiltily admitting that the enclosed space feels more like a prison than a sanctuary.

Claire-Louise Bennett employs a similar juxtaposition of admiration, awe, and contentment with scepticism, guilt, and despair in her 2015 collection *Pond*. Bennett deliberately engages with the tradition of the pastoral in her narrative of an unnamed protagonist who has abandoned the city for the countryside in search of clarity, distance, and authenticity. The stories are set in a remote area near a lake, a reference to a classic of the pastoral mode, Henry David Thoreau's *Walden*,[53] yet Bennett turns the pastoral tradition on its head. Instead of depicting the countryside as pleasant, idyllic, or restorative, the narrator increasingly sees her surroundings and herself as unsettling, terrifying, awe-inspiring, and dream-like. Instead of returning to civilisation wiser and more refreshed, she ends up resisting her return, hoping to remain in the dark with her monsters, whom she comes to see as an essential part of her own being.[54]

The narrator adopts the same ambivalent attitude towards her garden. She is a reluctant gardener who claims she has decided "once and for all" that she didn't "want to be in the business of turning things into other things",[55] yet she finds that she is compelled to

[50]Moss, *The Fell*, 34–6.
[51]Ibid., 152.
[52]Ibid, 34–5.
[53]Gallix, "*Pond* by Claire-Louise Bennett Review."
[54]Bennett, *Pond*, 143.
[55]Ibid., 135.

do so regardless. Although she rationally perceives any action, and especially action in which she attempts to alter "nature", as pointless, once she starts, she is seemingly unable to stop:

> [...] interfering is something I really loathe in almost all its applications. So, I was trimming – pruning you might call it – and pulling up weeds and patting the soil back down, and I soon felt like one of those ladies I'd see from the car window on the way to my grandparents' house with their ample backsides and baggy gardening gloves when I was much smaller. This is mindless, I thought, and very unflattering – stop it at once. But I didn't stop because I was so curious to find out what changed if I carried on. [...] I wasn't pitting myself against nature or anything as hammy as that – I was suddenly desperate to get rid of all this disheveled foliage, it's true, but the reason I soon realized was because I wanted to get to bare soil – I missed it – it was all covered over and I wanted so much to push everything aside and see the earth.[56]

In this passage the conflicting feelings of despair and futility at the pointlessness of trying to change the course of nature are warring with an even stronger drive to affect change: to simply see what might happen. The narrator subconsciously senses the intra-action between herself and the world and feels compelled to reconnect with the soil, albeit tentatively. In *Second Nature*, Michael Pollan referred to this emotion as the "gardener's sublime", a state of mind different from the romantic sublime in which one is astonished by the vast scope and power of nature. Instead, gardeners acknowledge that they are part of the sublime, active participants in the drama of "nature":

> The gardener doesn't lose himself, much less his body, in his particular reverie. For as much as you are being acted upon by everything around you this July afternoon, you are acting too, urging as well as listening, conducting that desultory conversation with nature that is gardening in summertime. And though it may not last very long [...], at times like these the green thumb's way through nature seems clearly marked, easy to follow, almost second nature. So simple: grace in the garden but a form of puttering.[57]

Just like the narrator in *Pond*, Pollan believes that his intra-action with the rest of the natural world is desultory and contingent – he is merely "puttering" and remains fully aware that everything which he accomplishes is transitory. Nonetheless, he clearly feels that it is exactly this kind of agency that makes sense. As with *Pond's* narrator, the act of gardening demonstrates to Pollan that he is not pitting himself against nature but working in tandem with everything else, participating actively in the eternal cycle of growth and decay. This foregrounding of the complexities and contradictions inherent in existence, along with an emphasis on the continuity between all beings and all matter, are the defining features of Gifford's post-pastoral literary mode.

The gardens which feature in the four books under study are never finished, never completely separated from the rest of the world, and certainly not self-contained. The characters are constantly reminded of their entanglement with other beings, but also with the rest of matter. In *The High House*, Caro muses:

> We are not self-sufficient. There is no such thing. We rely on the stores we have left in the barn. We rely on the chickens, but the flock is shrinking. We rely on the wheat, but one bad year and we will have none left to sow as seed. We rely on the tide pool and the generator

[56]Ibid., 117.
[57]Pollan, *Second Nature*, 133–4.

> which we cannot fix if it breaks. We rely on the high house, on its fabric, on its shelter and protection, but these things will not last forever. We rely on one another.[58]

In the garden of Greengrass' novel, not only the plants and animals (both human and non-human) are active agents in the cycle of growth-consumption-decay but also all of the objects found within it. The wheat, chickens, humans, the generator, the seeds, and the house itself all co-create a mesh that makes life possible. Yet this harmony is always temporary and when one or more of the participants inevitably cease to fulfil their role, the entire cycle is subject to collapse.

In "A New Concept for Fighting Climate Change", Elizabeth Rush opines that in order to successfully conceptualise nature, we need to redefine the categories of animate and inanimate: we need to "foreground non-human actors", including those we traditionally consider as not alive, such as rivers or glaciers, by making explicit their agency.[59] This is one of the strategies employed by Bennett, Greengrass, Hildyard, and Moss. Hildyard paints a landscape in which trees, children, gravel, abandoned construction machines, and foxes all act upon the world and upon each other. A neighbour "populates" his garden pond "with newts, frogs, and a plastic floating decoy duck",[60] allowing the living and synthetic birds to occupy the space as equals. The poisonous yew, which he gives to the narrator's mother as seasoning for her cooking claiming it is rosemary, is described as moving through the narrator's intestines of its own volition, "mapp[ing] out the physical passage of his frustrated sense of humour".[61] On a different day, when the narrator steps upon a heap of garden compost, she can "see puffs of steam or spores around" her feet, and becomes petrified that the tiny beings living inside the heap will swarm through her skin, entering and invading her stomach, which is simultaneously being attacked from within by a swallowed piece of chewing-gum "lurk[ing] and radiat[ing] its fatal particles" into her body.[62] In *Emergency*, the garden is depicted as an ecosystem without boundaries, an entity which both fascinates and terrifies the narrator. She feels a unity with the cannibalistic rabbit, the swallowed pieces of yew, and the compost bacteria, yet at the same time she is aware that their coexistence is precarious and always prone to fatal consequences.

The representation of the continuity of matter and being and the revelation that objects traditionally considered as inanimate in fact possess agency is central to the post-pastoral mode. In *New Forms of Environmental Writing: Gleaning and Fragmentation*, Timothy Baker explains how contemporary authors make use of fragmentation and what he calls "gleaning", that is the presentation of narrative as a collection of fragments, to achieve such effects. In an attempt to capture the complexity and interconnection of the world, these authors foreground "the momentary encounter" and "the daily ritual",[63] focusing on the mundane as a manifestation of the real. The technique of fragmentation represents "a complicated response to environmental concerns that makes a virtue of uncertainty and accident" and a "way of challenging received narratives of environmental engagement".[64] Timothy Morton describes the interconnectedness of ecosystems using

[58]Greengrass, *The High House*, 223.
[59]Rush, "A New Concept for Fighting Climate Change."
[60]Hildyard, *Emergency*, 46.
[61]Ibid.
[62]Ibid., 61.
[63]Baker, *New Forms of Environmental Writing,* 14.
[64]Ibid.

the metaphor of a mesh. The mesh is a network of intertwined beings and objects that is "vast, perhaps immeasurably so"[65] and defined by a pervasive strangeness. Within the mesh, "nothing exists all by itself, and so nothing is fully 'itself.'"[66] Instead, objects and beings coexist in complex relationships and any attempt at fully knowing or defining them necessarily fails.

Baker argues that fragmentation and gleaning make possible a representation of such fundamentally interconnected and ultimately unknowable ecosystems by focusing on the momentary and partial and allowing for uncertainty and coincidence. These two techniques are employed extensively in all four of the books under study. Although Sarah Moss's novel can be interpreted as a linear narrative of the protagonist's abortive attempt to escape quarantine, Moss structures the text in a way that prevents such a simple reading. The point of view is constantly shifting, with each chapter narrated by a different character. The chapters themselves are titled with cryptic statements, and the narrative flows as a series of fragmented thoughts and memories recounted as a sequence of random associations. The conclusion of the novel is left open, indicating that the narrative itself is merely a fragment of a larger story. Similar methods of fragmentation are employed by the other three writers. *Emergency*, *The High House*, and the stories collected in *Pond* are all very loosely plotted and structured as a stream of memories and musings with open endings. In *The High House*, Greengrass also employs multiple points of view, while *Pond* is a great example of what Baker calls "fragmented form".[67] The stories that form the collection feature minimal plots. Instead, they are made up of loosely connected observations, memories, dreams, and philosophical musing of the protagonist. The timeframe of events is unclear, the collection is written almost entirely in the form of interior monologue, and almost no background information is provided about the protagonist or any of the minor characters. The effect Bennett achieves is that of fragmentation and disorientation.

The narrative of *Emergency* is filled with gleaned collections of fragments, much like the gardens in which it is set:

> We walked past a huge henhouse which was a miniature version of the main house, except, on the inside walls, somebody had painted magnificent bare-breasted women, some with fishtails, others combing their hair, wearing shells or pearls, or trailing seaweed which covered or revealed their nakedness. "Suzie's thing," said Ruth. "Bit camp."
>
> She marched us around the different gardens inside the garden, barking out the Latin names of the plants and informing us as to whether they were thriving or weak. Then we went into the hothouse.
>
> [...] These plants were labelled with small white placards on plastic sticks that had been pushed into the damp compost. The Latin names of the plants meant nothing to me but I had heard of their places of origin: Barbados, Trinidad, Carolina, Florida, Georgia. Some olden person had annotated these labels in looped handwriting with notes on the environment that the original seed, cutting, or entire plant had been lifted from: forest, mountain, swamp, plantation.[68]

[65]Morton, *The Ecological Thought*, 15.
[66]Ibid.
[67]Ibid.
[68]Hildyard, *Emergency*, 95.

The garden described here seems like an amalgamation of various random objects that together form a haphazard whole. At the same time, however, it is a paradise of sorts, an ancient, enchanted place, in which the narrator "wouldn't have been surprised to see a beady eye or scaly tail or long golden feather flick and disappear".[69] This magical scene is as much a result of human creativity as it is a product of natural forces beyond human control. The miniature henhouse and the paintings of bare-breasted women coexist in an eclectic ecosystem with the plants expanding inside the hothouse, covering the glass with moisture and bringing matter from all over the globe to this one spot in England. Hildyard depicts such gleaned collections of items frequently throughout the novel. More importantly, she also uses the technique of gleaning as the central structuring principle of the narrative. The plot of *Emergency* is presented as a series of collected memories and seemingly random events from the protagonist's childhood and teenage years. The haphazard and fragmentary nature of the narrative helps Hildyard portray the protagonist as enmeshed in a world that is complex and ultimately incomprehensible.

Despite It All, the Garden Sustains Life

In times of uncertainty, people often yearn for action; they keep themselves busy in an attempt to maintain a sense of control, to ward off panic or manage their grief. In an age defined by pervasive solastalgia, in which climate change creates an ever-present, crippling sense of uncertainty over the future, constantly forcing us to consider whether the Earth will still be habitable a couple of years from now, gardening has often been presented as a form of action that can help us cope with the coming disaster or even overcome it. But while the portrayal of gardening in the media tends towards the sentimental pastoral, with gardens presented as an antidote to the exploitation of natural resources and our alienation from nature, the literary works discussed in this paper offer a more complicated perspective. In these four books, gardens are construed as post-pastoral landscapes in which humans are embedded in the fabric of all matter on Earth. These gardens are an integral part of the world, affected by climate change, filled with plastics and machines but also with birds, vegetables, compost, children, and bacteria. In this sense, the books echo Haraway's understanding of the world as a web of "ordinary knotted beings"[70] in which "[t]o be one is always to become with many".[71] This web of ordinary beings is embodied, firmly rooted in matter, and all life in this world unfolds in the form of "a multipartner mud dance issuing from and in entangled species".[72]

This innovative approach allows the four authors to highlight the artificiality of the Manichean distinctions between nature and civilisation, wilderness and society, and the human and non-human. Yet despite their refusal to romanticise gardens and gardening as a cure-all for our ecological woes, each of the four books acknowledges the power of actively engaging with the material world, especially by growing and eating our own food. The figure of the gardener is portrayed as an embodiment of knowledge, care, and

[69]Ibid.
[70]Haraway, *When Species Meet*, 5.
[71]Ibid., 4.
[72]Ibid., 32.

survival. In *The High House*, the village caretaker, Grandy, tends to the gardens surrounding the holiday cottages after their owners have returned to their homes in the city:

> The village was his. It was he who looked after it. The apples which ripened in September in all the trees in all the gardens were Grandy's, and the pears, and he stored them in whichever sheds had room for them, laying them side by side in rows, not touching, so he could go back for them as he wanted through the winter – and he made cider, plastic bins of pulp fermenting in his own shed to be strained, later, through old pillowcases hung from a hook in the kitchen roof. The results were poured into demijohns and kept in the airing cupboard for the winter. If you stood outside the cupboard, even with the door shut, you could hear them, bubbling softly away to themselves. It was always a comforting sound.[73]

Grandy's intimate knowledge of the gardens and what grows and lives in them allows him to preside over the village like an anima locus. Yet it is made clear in the novel that he is only able to thrive in this place because he works in tandem with everything else that inhabits it: the apple trees, the insects, the driftwood. After the flood, Grandy becomes instrumental to the survival of the four characters. Throughout the story he teaches them the skills they need to maintain their garden and grow food for themselves. Finally, at the end of the novel, he becomes a martyr figure, sacrificing his life to save Caro and Sally. And although his eventual death is a reminder that survival is a transitory state, his life stands as a testament to the fact that even under the harshest of circumstances, we are compelled to go on living – we cannot keep from participating in the eternal cycle of matter.

In *The Fell*, Kate ruminates on this cycle while standing in her garden, imagining the people and vegetables that used to occupy that same plot of land in the past:

> She does think about them sometimes, the original inhabitants, the stirring of porridge and pottage where she now fries tofu and grills peppers but also stirs bean soup of the sort they'd surely have eaten with probably the same vegetables from the same garden as those Victorian miners, grown in earth that probably still holds the nutrients of their nightsoil, the afterlives of their bodies present in her and Matt, and aren't we all just rearrangements of the same atoms, which could maybe somehow be a comforting thought but isn't, not particularly.[74]

In this passage, and indeed in all of the examples discussed above, ambivalence is the dominant tone. The cycle of life and decay offers little comfort, yet it is inevitable. And if it is so, the best course of action might be to become active participants in it by planting, growing, tending, eating, and discharging the stuff of the world that is also the stuff of our gardens. The gardens depicted in *Pond*, *The High House*, *Emergency*, and *The Fell*, are by no means idyllic but they are undoubtedly sublime. Their beauty, simultaneously bizarre and terrifying, stems not from an aesthetic arrangement of plants, but from the realisation that the vegetables, fruits, and (human and non-human) animals that live in them embody the fundamental and inescapable cycle of growth and decay that is existence.

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[73]Greengrass, *The High House*, 62.
[74]Moss, *The Fell*, 21–2.

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